

AP PHOTO/MUSTAFA QURAISHI



POWER OF THREE: Modi, Advani and Rajnath unite as a formidable force in the run-up to the general elections

meet, Swaraj pointed out, "Since 1989, BJP has won 297 Lok Sabha seats at least once on its own." To this, Advani added the NDA math: "If we include the 64 won by our stable allies like Akali Dal, Shiv Sena, Janata Dal and Biju Janata Dal, then this number goes up to 361." In other words, NDA can win a "decisive majority" if it gives a "credible agenda of change". The feel-good factor is not restricted to BJP alone but Advani is quick to add a statutory warning. We have been over-confident before, he says.

Unlike Vajpayee who provided the poetic flourish, Advani has always been the pragmatic face of the party. In 1989, when Vajpayee was against a tie-up with the fundamentalist Shiv Sena, it was Advani who had pushed for it, pointing out that while BJP had a strong base in Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, it needed to shore up strength in Maharashtra and Gujarat. And as he recently reminded his party, it was he who had invited the Samata Party

Having been given his licence to drive, the charioteer of Indian politics hopes that the ride will end at 7 Race Course Road.

leaders to the party national council in 1995 and that was the first tentative step towards the formation of NDA.

Advani has not just the message but even the machinery in place. Days after he was chosen as BJP's prime ministerial face, he set up a 19-member election management committee under Rajnath's leadership to prepare

the party for future polls. Making Rajnath in charge was a clear signal to the rest that he would not be undermining the party chief. Both Rajnath and Modi have emerged as key players in Advani's BJP. One as his chief organisational strategist, while the other as the star campaigner. This is the troika that will be the face of BJP in the run-up to the next general elections. Interestingly, all three come from a strong RSS background and have worked their way up from the grassroots. The Modi-Advani harmony was showcased in the duo's lavish praise of each other. "The media asks me, is Modi bigger than the party? If a junior does well, the elder doesn't feel unhappy, he feels proud," said Advani, scoffing at those who were trying to pit Modi against him.

The Advani team 2008 is slowly taking shape. Swaraj's role in the party has grown ever since Advani's prime ministerial candidature was announced. She has emerged as the unofficial spokesperson for the campaign